

Buckingham Palace - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The House That Became a Palace

Through these railings you are looking at the most famous front door in Britain, the official London residence of the sovereign. Yet Buckingham Palace spent its first century not as a palace at all, but as a private house, and that unlikely origin is the key to everything that follows.

It began in seventeen oh three, when John Sheffield, the Duke of Buckingham, built himself a fashionable town mansion on this spot, known simply as Buckingham House. In seventeen sixty one, King George the Third bought it for twenty one thousand pounds, not as a showpiece but as a comfortable private home for his wife, Queen Charlotte. It became known as the Queen's House, and fourteen of the couple's fifteen children were born within its walls.

The transformation into a true palace came under their son, George the Fourth, a monarch of famously extravagant taste. He commissioned the brilliant, spendthrift architect John Nash to reinvent the house on a colossal scale. Nash's genius came with ruinous bills, and he was eventually dismissed, the work finished more soberly by Edward Blore. George the Fourth died before it was ready, and never lived here.

The first sovereign actually to move in was the young Queen Victoria, in July eighteen thirty seven, only weeks into her reign and just eighteen years old. From that moment, Buckingham Palace became, and has remained, the official London home of the monarchy. Every ruler since has lived here.

The longer story of how the royal residence migrated across London over the centuries, before finally settling here, belongs to another stop on our tour. What matters at these gates is that this became the destination, the place the crown came to rest.

A word on timing. It is about ten in the morning on a Thursday, so there is no Changing of the Guard today, that ceremony runs on other days, and in this heatwave you may be glad to be spared the crush. We will encounter the mounted sentries of the Household Cavalry a little later, over on Whitehall. And you have arrived in a fortunate window, because the State Rooms are open for their annual summer season right now, so behind this very facade, ticket-holders are walking through the palace's grandest interiors. Let me fill in the stories behind the stone.

The Queen's House

Let us dwell on the building's quiet beginnings, because they are more charming than its later grandeur suggests. When George the Third acquired Buckingham House in seventeen sixty one, he was a young king, newly married to Charlotte of Mecklenburg-Strelitz, and what he wanted was not a stage for royal spectacle but a private family retreat, conveniently close to the formal court at nearby St James's Palace.

The house suited that purpose beautifully. It was handsome, comfortable, and set in its own gardens, and the King and Queen filled it with domestic life on a grand scale. They had fifteen children in all, and all but one were born here, in what everyone came to call the Queen's House. For decades this was, in effect,

a royal family home rather than a palace of state, and the difference in feeling would have been obvious to anyone who stepped inside.

George the Third was also a man of serious intellectual passions, and the house reflected them. He was a devoted collector of books, assembling one of the finest libraries in the country, thousands upon thousands of volumes that eventually formed the core of the King's Library now held by the British Library. He loved fine clocks, maps and scientific instruments too, and the rooms hummed with the mechanisms of a curious, orderly mind.

There is a gentle irony worth savouring here. The building that would become the ultimate symbol of royal ceremony and public display began its royal life as very nearly the opposite, a place of privacy, family, and quiet study. The grandeur was bolted on later, by a different king with a very different temperament.

So when you picture the palace's origins, do not picture crowds and gold. Picture a scholarly king among his books and clocks, a large brood of children underfoot, and a house that was loved precisely because it felt like a home. That domestic character never entirely left the building, even after it grew into the vast working palace we see today. It is a useful thing to carry with you at the railings, because the frontage in front of you was engineered to project power, and yet the thing it wraps around was, at its heart, somebody's family home.

Nash's Ambition and Victoria's Arrival

The leap from comfortable house to imperial palace was the work of one restless king and one audacious architect. George the Fourth, who came to the throne in eighteen twenty, had already lavished fortunes on the Royal Pavilion at Brighton and on Windsor. Now he turned to the Queen's House, determined to convert it into a palace worthy of a great nation, and he chose John Nash, the visionary behind the sweep of Regent Street, to do it.

Nash's design was magnificent and hopelessly expensive. Parliament had sanctioned a fairly modest budget, but the costs spiralled far beyond it, and the architect's reputation went down with the overspend. After George the Fourth died in eighteen thirty, an official inquiry effectively ended Nash's involvement, and the more cautious Edward Blore was engaged to complete the palace. George the Fourth never spent a night here, and his successor, William the Fourth, disliked the place so much that he once offered it to Parliament as a replacement chamber after their own building burned down.

It fell to Victoria to make the palace a home and a symbol at once. She came to the throne in June eighteen thirty seven and moved in that July, the first monarch to reside here. She quickly discovered its flaws, poor ventilation, smoking chimneys, and doors that would not close, and later had Blore add the East Front, the very range you are looking at, to gain more family space. That addition was famously funded by selling off George the Fourth's beloved Brighton Pavilion.

And then there is the balcony. The famous central balcony belongs to that East Front, and Victoria was the first sovereign to use it for a public appearance, at the opening of the Great Exhibition in eighteen fifty one. From that moment a tradition was born. The balcony became the stage on which the monarchy shows itself to the nation, at coronations, at royal weddings, and after every Trooping the Colour since. It is worth remembering, as you look at that modest stone platform, how much national emotion it has absorbed over nearly two centuries.

The Blitz and the Working Palace

The palace's finest hour, in reputation at least, came in its most dangerous days. During the Second World War, King George the Sixth and Queen Elizabeth made the deliberate choice to remain in London through the Blitz rather than retreat to safety, and Buckingham Palace shared the fate of the city around

it. It was struck on several occasions, most seriously on the thirteenth of September nineteen forty, when a raider flew straight up the line of the Mall and dropped a stick of bombs into the quadrangle, destroying the royal chapel. The King and Queen were in the building at the time.

Out of that near miss came one of the most quoted royal remarks of the century. With the working-class districts of the East End being pounded night after night, Queen Elizabeth reflected that she was almost glad the palace had been hit, because now, she said, she could look the East End in the face. Whether or not the phrasing was polished afterward, the sentiment landed, and it cemented the popular affection that carried the monarchy through the war and beyond. The palace was damaged around nine times before peace returned.

Today the building is less a home than a headquarters, the administrative heart of a modern monarchy. Around it revolves a working machine of investitures, state banquets, audiences and receptions, with a large resident staff and a constant diplomatic traffic. The garden absorbs thousands of guests at summer garden parties, and the state apartments serve as the ceremonial face the nation presents to the world.

For a visitor, the happy consequence is access. Each summer, while the sovereign is away, the State Rooms open to the public, and that season is running during your visit. Behind this facade, in rooms hung with Rembrandts and Canalettos and lit by chandeliers the size of small cars, ordinary ticket-holders are seeing the palace much as visiting heads of state do. It remains, in the truest sense, a working palace, and you have caught it with its doors ajar.

What the Gates Let You See

From behind these railings you get the classic view, the East Front facing down the Mall, and it rewards a careful eye. Almost everything the public associates with Buckingham Palace, the balcony, the flag, the ceremonial forecourt, sits on this one elevation. The rest, the older wings and the private world, is hidden behind it. So let us make the most of what is actually visible.

The facade before you is long, restrained, and faced in pale Portland stone, deliberately understated for a royal palace. Its focal point is the central balcony, the most famous few square metres of stonework in Britain, from which the royal family greets the crowds on great occasions. Fix its position in your mind, because on an ordinary day it looks almost modest, easy to overlook.

Now the flag, and a genuinely useful piece of decoding. Look to the flagpole on the roofline. If the Royal Standard is flying, the quartered banner of lions and a harp, the sovereign is in residence at this very moment. If instead you see the red, white and blue Union Flag, the King is away. This has only been the convention since nineteen ninety seven, before which the palace flew a flag only when the monarch was present, and it remains the quickest way to know whether anyone royal is home.

The scale hidden behind the front is hard to credit. The palace contains seven hundred and seventy five rooms, including seventy eight bathrooms and nineteen state rooms, and behind it lies a thirty nine acre garden, the largest private garden in London. You are seeing perhaps a fifth of the whole thing.

And dominating the forecourt is the Victoria Memorial, the great confection of marble and gilt that anchors this entire set piece. We will give it, and the layered history of the facade itself, their own closer look. For now, standing here in the heatwave by the railings, simply take in how much this single, disciplined frontage is designed to do, and how much it is designed to conceal.

The Facade Is Younger Than You Think

The elevation in front of you is an architectural palimpsest, the work of three hands across nearly a century, and untangling them is one of the quiet pleasures of standing here.

Start with the bones. John Nash, working for George the Fourth in the eighteen twenties, created the palace we would half recognise, three ranges built around an open courtyard, a great U opening toward the Mall, faced in warm Bath stone with a French neoclassical flourish. Nash's core still stands, though you cannot see much of it from here, because it was later boxed in.

The boxing-in was the work of Edward Blore, who in eighteen forty seven closed off Nash's open courtyard with an entirely new East Front, the range that now faces you and conceals the quadrangle behind. Blore's front was built by the great contractor Thomas Cubitt, and the whole enterprise was paid for by selling George the Fourth's Royal Pavilion at Brighton. It was Blore's front, incidentally, that displaced Marble Arch, which was shifted to its present home near Hyde Park.

Now the surprise. Blore's stonework weathered badly in London's coal soot, and by the early twentieth century it looked distinctly shabby. So in nineteen thirteen the architect Sir Aston Webb refaced the entire East Front in gleaming Portland stone, the surface you see today. The astonishing part is the speed. Webb had the new stone cut and prepared in advance, and the actual refacing on site was carried out in roughly thirteen weeks, timed to begin the moment the royal family left for their summer holidays and to finish before they returned.

So the face of Buckingham Palace, the image on a million postcards, is the newest layer of all, barely a century old, wrapped around Blore's Victorian front, which in turn encloses Nash's Georgian palace.

When you photograph the balcony, you are photographing Webb's Edwardian skin over Blore's bones over Nash's heart. Few great buildings wear their history quite so literally, one coat pulled on over another. And there is a neat symmetry to it, since Webb was refacing the palace at almost exactly the moment he was completing the Victoria Memorial just in front, so the whole tableau you are looking at, building and monument together, is essentially a single Edwardian composition laid over three earlier centuries.

The Wedding Cake and the Hidden Palace

Turn your attention to the great white monument commanding the forecourt, the Victoria Memorial. It is the work of the sculptor Sir Thomas Brock, designed in nineteen oh one after Victoria's death and unveiled by her grandson George the Fifth in nineteen eleven, though the surrounding scheme was not fully finished until the nineteen twenties. Londoners, with characteristic irreverence, have long called it the wedding cake.

The seated figure facing down the Mall is Victoria herself, carved from gleaming white marble, gazing out over the empire she came to symbolise. Around the base are allegorical groups, figures standing for courage, constancy, truth and motherhood among them, and the whole composition rises to a gilded bronze figure of Winged Victory at the summit, flanked by Constancy and Courage. That gold catches the light on the dullest day, which is rather the point. There is a pleasing story that George the Fifth was so moved at the unveiling that he called for a sword and knighted Brock on the spot, and in this case the tale appears to be true.

Notice, too, how the memorial and the palace facade were conceived as a pair. Aston Webb designed both the Portland stone front and this monumental setting, which is why the pale stone of the building and the white marble of the memorial read as a single, unified composition rather than two separate things.

As for the palace behind, its scale defies the modest frontage. Seven hundred and seventy five rooms, seventy eight bathrooms, ninety two offices and nineteen state rooms, plus a swimming pool, a cinema, a post office and a surgery, all invisible from the street. Behind it all stretches the thirty nine acre garden, the largest private garden in London, with its own lake, more than a thousand trees, and a helicopter lawn, where the sovereign hosts thousands of guests at summer garden parties.

What you see from the railings, then, is a beautifully composed mask, gilt Victory, white marble and pale stone, all arranged to impress, and behind it a small, self-contained city that the public almost never gets to see.

The King's Address, Over a Thousand Years

Here is a question worth carrying through the whole of this trip. Where does the King of England actually live? You are standing at the answer right now, in front of Buckingham Palace. But that answer is barely two centuries old. For most of English history the crown lived somewhere else entirely, and it moved, house by house, across this city over the better part of a thousand years. Follow the moves, and you have a thread that ties nearly every stop on our journey together.

Start where we started, on Monday. The oldest royal home in London is the Tower of London, the great Norman fortress William the Conqueror began just after ten sixty six. For centuries kings genuinely lived there, in royal lodgings behind those walls, and we will come back to why they eventually stopped.

Then the court moved upriver to the Palace of Westminster, the medieval seat of the monarchy, right beside the Abbey where kings were crowned. You will see its site later today, because that is where Parliament and Big Ben now stand. It was the principal royal residence of the late Middle Ages, until a fire in fifteen twelve gutted the royal apartments and, in effect, ended it as a home.

The crown moved a few hundred yards up the road to Whitehall. And here is a fact that stops people cold. Whitehall Palace grew into the largest palace in Europe, more than fifteen hundred rooms, bigger even than Versailles. You will walk right past its grave this afternoon, on the street still called Whitehall, because in sixteen ninety eight it burned to the ground in a single catastrophic night. One building survived, the Banqueting House, and it stands there still, the only real fragment left of the greatest palace in Europe.

After Whitehall burned, the court fell back on St James's Palace, the red brick Tudor palace that borders the park we are about to walk through. And here is the subtlety that surprises everyone. St James's, not Buckingham, is still officially the senior palace of the realm. To this day foreign ambassadors are formally sent to the Court of St James's, never the Court of Buckingham Palace.

And then, at last, this. Buckingham became the sovereign's London home only when the young Queen Victoria moved in, in eighteen thirty seven. The address you are looking at is the newest of them all.

So there is your thread. Tower, Westminster, Whitehall, St James's, Buckingham. Let me take you deeper into each.

Why the Kings Left the Tower

On Monday we spent our morning inside the oldest royal home in this story, the Tower of London, so let us close that loop. When William the Conqueror raised the great White Tower just after the conquest, it was two things at once, a fortress to overawe a conquered city, and a palace to house its new king. For the Norman and early Plantagenet kings that was precisely the point, safety and majesty inside one set of walls. Henry the Third and his son Edward the First built comfortable royal lodgings within, painted, glazed and warm.

But a fortress makes an uneasy home, and over the centuries the balance tipped. As England grew more settled, kings came to prefer the comfort and space of Westminster and Whitehall to the cramped, forbidding Tower. By the Tudor age it had become a place a monarch visited for a particular reason rather than lived in. Tradition held that a sovereign spent the night before their coronation there, then processed out through the city to the Abbey. The last monarch to lodge there was James the First, in sixteen oh three. After that, no king or queen has ever lived in it again.

What the Tower became instead is exactly what you saw on Monday. It turned into the nation's strongroom and stronghold at once, an armoury, a mint, a menagerie of exotic animals, and a prison for the very highest and most dangerous prisoners, some of whom left only for the executioner's block. Above all it became the treasure house of the Crown Jewels, which are still guarded there today, and which you filed past behind the glass. The Yeoman Warders you met, the Beefeaters in their dark and scarlet coats, are the living remnant of the royal bodyguard that once protected a king in residence. The king left, but his guards, in a sense, never did.

So when you remember the ravens and the jewels and the cold stone of Monday morning, remember this too. You were standing in the crown's very first London address, the place this whole thousand year journey began, before it set off on the road that ends here at these railings.

The Palaces Still to Come

The thread does not end at these railings, because on this trip you are going to meet several more royal homes, and each one adds something the London story leaves out. Tomorrow you go to Hampton Court, the sprawling riverside palace upstream that was Henry the Eighth's favourite of some sixty houses. Henry seized it from his fallen minister Cardinal Wolsey and turned it into a pleasure palace, a place of feasts, tennis, gardens and sheer display. It was a genuine seat of government too, the Privy Council met there, but it was always fundamentally a country retreat, too far from the City ever to become the crown's permanent capital. William the Third loved it enough to have Christopher Wren graft a whole baroque palace onto the Tudor one, which is why tomorrow you will see two utterly different palaces fused into a single building. The royals left it for good around seventeen thirty seven, and no monarch has lived there since.

Then there is the half of the story that London forgets entirely. The King is King of Scotland too, and Scotland has its own royal homes, which you will see next week. In Edinburgh you will stand between the two ends of the Royal Mile, a mighty fortress at the top, Edinburgh Castle, high on its volcanic rock, and an elegant palace at the bottom, the Palace of Holyroodhouse. Holyroodhouse is the King's official residence in Scotland to this day, where he stays for a week each summer, exactly as Buckingham is his home in England. Later still you will visit Stirling Castle, another great royal stronghold perched on its own crag, where Scottish kings and queens were crowned and raised, and where the infant Mary, Queen of Scots, was kept safe as a child.

So keep a running count as we travel. The crown does not have one home, it has a whole constellation of them, quite literally two capitals' worth, one in England and one in Scotland. Every castle and palace we visit on this holiday is another room in the same very large royal life.

Palace or Castle

One last distinction, because it clears up a puzzle that trips up almost everyone. Why are some royal homes called palaces and others castles? The answer is simple and genuinely useful. A castle was built to be defended, with thick walls, towers and a commanding position, a machine for war that a king could also live in. A palace was built purely to be lived in and to impress, no arrow slits, no ramparts, only grandeur. The Tower, Edinburgh and Stirling are castles. Buckingham, St James's, Holyroodhouse and Hampton Court are palaces. The word itself tells you what the building was for.

The great exception, and the most famous royal home of all, is Windsor Castle, just west of London. It began as one of William the Conqueror's ring of fortresses guarding the capital, and it is a castle in every sense, yet it has been lived in by monarchs continuously for nearly a thousand years, longer than any other, which makes it the oldest and largest inhabited castle in the world. It is a fortress that simply never stopped being a home.

Two smaller names complete the London constellation. Kensington Palace, on the far side of Hyde Park, is where the young Victoria was born and grew up before she moved into Buckingham. And Kew Palace, a modest red brick house tucked into the botanic gardens, is the smallest royal palace of all, a quiet family retreat for George the Third, the same king who first bought Buckingham House down the road as a home for his wife.

Put it all together and the picture is clear. The crown has never really had a single home. It has a scattered family of them, fortresses and palaces, grand and modest, in two countries, each collected in a different century for a different reason. Buckingham, where you are standing, is simply the one where the long story finally came to rest. And so, the next time someone asks you where the King of England lives, you will know that the honest answer is a thousand years long.